

The Waterfront Brief

Weekly sustainment intelligence for naval shipyard leadership · Naval shipbuilding, ship repair, and fleet sustainment

Vol. 1, No. 4 — Week 32

August 7, 2026

Four changes are moving through the system this week, and none of them is a contract award. The Navy has written down that it is giving up on the long, everything-at-once availability. A House committee has reported a defense bill that would hand whole categories of surface combatant to single yards for five-year terms. The federal award records for Navy shipboard air conditioning show one supplier, two standing contracts titled for new construction, and the government's own written finding that no alternative exists. And the Navy's largest overseas repair facility finished a carrier availability on time and then lost its entire command team for the second time in twenty months.

Three of the four are documents rather than events: a plan, a bill and two contract records. Labels: FACT is attributed to the named source in the same sentence; Assessment is this desk's analysis, built only on facts stated above it; Speculation is flagged as such.

WATERFRONT OPS & PRODUCTION

A carrier came out of a Japanese yard on time, and then the command team was relieved

FACT: the Defense Visual Information Distribution Service reported on June 28, 2026 that the Naval Ship Repair Facility and Japan Regional Maintenance Center at Yokosuka completed Chief of Naval Operations maintenance availabilities for the destroyer USS *Shoup* and the aircraft carrier USS *George Washington*, returning both to the fleet on time on May 11 and May 13, 2026. A CNO availability is a maintenance period large enough that the Navy's own headquarters, rather than a local command, owns the schedule and the money.

FACT: Stars and Stripes reported on June 3, 2026 that the command provides intermediate- and depot-level maintenance for Navy surface ships assigned to the 7th Fleet, supports operations throughout Japan and Southeast Asia, employs approximately 120 military personnel, 325 civilians and 2,500 Japanese workers, and operates facilities at Yokosuka, at Sasebo Naval Base and in Singapore. FACT: the same report states that the commanding officer had highlighted the command's

2025 accomplishments at a New Year's event in January, including more than 714,000 man-days of ship repair and modernization work, support for maintenance operations in Singapore, and emergency response after a fire aboard the amphibious transport dock USS *New Orleans*.

FACT: USNI News reported on June 4, 2026 that Navy Regional Maintenance Center commander Rear Adm. Dan Lannamann had removed the commanding officer, the executive officer and the command master chief "due to a loss of confidence in their ability to command," and that the Navy statement said "there is no impact to the command's mission as a result of these reliefs."

FACT: the same USNI report states that a source familiar with the decision said the reliefs were due to conduct, not performance, but was unable to provide further details.

FACT: Stars and Stripes reported that this was the second such removal in twenty months, that the previous commanding officer and executive officer were relieved in October 2024, that Rear Adm. Lannamann had himself temporarily commanded the facility after those removals until the relieved commanding officer took over in February 2025, and that the supervisor of salvage and diving, the Navy office responsible for wreck removal, ship salvage and diving rather than for scheduled repair, has now assumed the commander's duties pending a permanent replacement.

Assessment: the only sourced statement about cause points away from delivery performance, and the timing invites the opposite reading. Resist it. A yard that finished a nuclear carrier availability on time in May and lost its top three in June is not evidence that the two are connected, and the one person quoted on the question says they are not.

Assessment: what the facts above do establish is a continuity problem. By the dates given, the relieved commanding officer held the job from February 2025 to June 2026, roughly sixteen months; the officer who removed him had himself been the stopgap after the previous pair went; and the current stopgap is a salvage and diving officer. Two complete turnovers in twenty months means the people who carry the command's method are its 325

civilians and 2,500 Japanese employees, because they are the ones who were there for all of it.

Assessment: the figure to write down is 714,000 man-days in calendar 2025, across three sites in two countries plus Singapore, on 7th Fleet surface ships at both intermediate and depot level. That is the scale of the forward node, and it is stated by the command about its own output rather than audited. The open question this issue cannot answer is whether that level holds through a second leadership reset, and the place it would show first is delivery dates on 7th Fleet availabilities.

Bottom line: the forward node did 714,000 man-days in 2025 across Yokosuka, Sasebo and Singapore, it has turned over its entire command team twice in twenty months, and the only sourced account says the reliefs were about conduct rather than output.

Sources: SRF-JRMC delivers two more ships to the fleet on time; Leaders of U.S. Navy's ship maintenance facility in Japan removed from command; Second leadership purge in 2 years hits Navy's largest overseas ship repair facility {sources}

Deckplate: the grievance process went away, and the supervisor's day changed with it

FACT: Government Executive reported on April 16, 2026 that an April 9, 2026 memorandum from the Secretary of Defense directed termination of all collective bargaining agreements to which the department is a party within twenty-four hours, citing national security, and that the exemption list covered unions already protected by court order, agency police, guards and firefighters, and Federal Wage System workers at four named installations: Letterkenny Munitions Center, the Air Force Test Center, the Air Force Sustainment Center and Fleet Readiness Center Southeast. No naval shipyard appears on that list. The Federal Wage System is the pay schedule covering trades and craft workers, as distinct from the salaried General Schedule.

FACT: Maine Public reported on April 20, 2026 that at Portsmouth Naval Shipyard agreements covering several hundred workers were terminated, that the Portsmouth Metal Trades Council's agreement survives only because of a court injunction, and quoted the American Federation of Government Employees' David Gonzalez saying "when you take away collective bargaining, there's no grievance process."

FACT: Government Executive reported on July 22, 2026 that the American Federation of Government Employees and the National Federation of Federal

Employees had moved for a preliminary injunction to restore the agreements, documenting management telling members the union "does not exist any longer," employees denied representation in disciplinary proceedings, and schedules changed unilaterally with little notice.

Assessment: strip out the politics and what is left is a change to the mechanics of a first-line supervisor's day. Three routine things that used to have a defined path now do not: how a discipline case proceeds, how a schedule change is communicated, and where a complaint goes. Those are the three the union official quoted above named, and they are the three a first-line supervisor touches most often.

Assessment: the planning problem is that this may reverse on a court's timetable rather than an operational one. One agreement at Portsmouth already survives only by injunction and two unions are asking a court to restore the rest, so a supervisor who rebuilds their practice around having no grievance process may have to rebuild it again. Practices that do not depend on which way that goes are the safer investment: writing down why a decision was made, and telling people about a schedule change before it happens, are practices no agreement required and no termination removed.

Bottom line: the contractual machinery around discipline, scheduling and complaints has been removed at a comparable yard and is being litigated, so the durable move is the practice that works under either regime.

Sources: Hegseth orders termination of union contracts; Trump admin ends collective bargaining agreements with 2 Portsmouth Naval Shipyard unions; Unions ask for injunction restoring collective bargaining {sources}

MAINTENANCE ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGIES

The Navy's shipboard air conditioning has one supplier, and the contract says so out loud

FACT: the federal award record for contract N6449825D4018 shows Naval Surface Warfare Center Philadelphia Division holding an indefinite-delivery, indefinite-quantity vehicle with Johnson Controls Navy Systems LLC, signed September 18, 2025 and running to September 17, 2028, with a base and all options value of \$202,336,475, coded "SINGLE AWARD," "ONLY ONE SOURCE," "NOT COMPETED" and "ONLY ONE SOURCE-OTHER (FAR 6.302-1 OTHER)." FACT: the record for

N6449825D4036 shows a second vehicle with the same company and the same office, signed September 12, 2025 and running to September 14, 2028, at \$197,225,022, carrying the identical competition coding. An indefinite-delivery vehicle is a standing contract with a ceiling; the actual work arrives later as delivery orders placed against it.

FACT: both USASpending records give the same description, "NEW CONSTRUCTION UNIT MARINEPAK R-134A," and classify Johnson Controls Navy Systems under air-conditioning and commercial and industrial refrigeration equipment manufacturing. FACT: both USASpending records also show a total obligation of zero.

Assessment: so the roughly \$399.6 million those two ceilings add up to is contract capacity that has been set up, not money that has been spent. Treat it as the size of the channel rather than the size of the order book.

A MarinePak is the packaged chiller unit that makes a warship's air conditioning and its cooling water for combat systems; R-134a is the refrigerant such a unit runs on.

Assessment: one company holds both vehicles, the government has recorded in each that no other source exists, and the description field on both says new construction.

Open question, and this issue does not answer it: through what vehicle the in-service fleet buys a replacement plant. These two records are titled for new construction and are the ones read here. Whether backfit work runs through them, through separate contracts, or through the same production line under a different label is not established by these records, and it is the question that decides whether a repair availability actually queues behind new hulls.

Assessment: the more useful signal is the competition coding, and it is worth reading literally. "Only one source" under FAR 6.302-1 is not a market opinion or an industry study. It is a contracting officer's formal written determination that no alternative supplier exists, recorded in the award. Where that code appears on a component your availability depends on, the schedule risk is not price and it is not competition; it is that there is exactly one queue.

Bottom line: read the "only one source" code as a schedule input, not a procurement detail, because it is the government stating in writing that the item your availability waits on has exactly one queue.

Sources: NSWC Philadelphia / Johnson Controls IDV N6449825D4018; NSWC Philadelphia / Johnson Controls IDV N6449825D4036 {.sources}

OPERATIONS READINESS

MAINTENANCE

&

The Navy has written down that it is done with the long availability

FACT: the Navy Shipbuilding Plan of May 2026 states that maintenance "will be performed through PAE Industrial Operations," a single organisation that "combines control of the Navy Regional Maintenance Centers, NAVSEA's Industrial Operations Directorate, the four Naval Shipyards and all Navy Regional Maintenance Centers." FACT: the same plan states that "the Navy will no longer attempt to restore all capabilities and add upgrades in a single, lengthy maintenance availability," moving instead to "smaller, more frequent availabilities." FACT: it also commits to reestablishing Shore Intermediate Maintenance Activities so sailors can perform "more advanced maintenance," and to a right-to-repair push against "proprietary lock-in on technical data packages." A Shore Intermediate Maintenance Activity is a shore command that does repair work above the ship's own crew but below a depot.

Assessment: read plainly, "smaller, more frequent" means more availabilities per year for the same fleet, and the plan as quoted does not say how many more or how much smaller. Those two figures are what a yard would need to size itself, because annual man-days and annual availability count can move in opposite directions under this change. Asking for them is the concrete next step.

A technical data package is the drawings, specifications and procedures needed to make or repair a part.

Assessment: the right-to-repair line is worth watching because the plan names it as an objective alongside the organisational change and the availability change, rather than as an aspiration. What the plan as quoted does not state is which systems are locked, or what the Navy would do differently once they were not.

Assessment: and the reestablishment of intermediate activities cuts both ways. The plan's stated purpose is to let sailors perform "more advanced maintenance," which by its own terms moves work that a crew or shore activity can do away from a depot. What that leaves behind is the work they cannot do. Whether that is a net relief or

a harder mix is not something the plan states, and it is worth watching rather than assuming.

Bottom line: the Navy has committed in writing to more and shorter availabilities under one new maintenance organisation, and the two figures it has not published, how many more and how much shorter, are the ones to ask for.

Sources: *Navy Shipbuilding Plan, May 2026*
{.sources}

BUSINESS PRACTICES & STRATEGY

A bill that would assign whole ship classes to single yards for five years

FACT: section 1018 of H.R. 8800, as reported in the House on June 15, 2026, directs the Navy to enter a single indefinite-delivery, indefinite-quantity contract for maintenance, repair and overhaul of surface combatants and to issue task orders “across availability periods” to private yards, with a separate task order for each category of vessel — a task order being the same mechanism as the delivery orders described earlier, an individual job placed against a standing contract — makes the yard holding a task order responsible for all routine, scheduled or corrective life-cycle maintenance on every vessel assigned to it, and provides that no contractor’s term may be shorter than five years. FACT: the same section requires the Navy, before awarding and within 180 days of enactment, to report vessel categories, parts and supply-chain forecasts, standardized work-item sequencing and bundling, and an assessment of workforce capacity and dry dock and pier availability, and directs the Secretary in setting categories to consider “the need to ensure adequate competition, and prevent the over-concentration of workload, among private shipyards.”

Assessment: this replaces competing for availabilities one at a time with being assigned a class of ship for a term of years. Whether a yard sits inside or outside a category would decide five years of workload in a single award, and the mandated pre-award report is the Navy formally writing down whose docks it plans to rely on. That report is the document to read when it appears, because it is a published statement of who the government thinks the industrial base is.

FACT: the Government Publishing Office’s own printing of that text labels it “H.R. 8800 Reported in House (RH)” and carries it on Union Calendar No. 606 under Report No. 119-698, which is the printed bill as a committee reported it rather than as either chamber passed it.

Assessment: so the honest frame is that none of this is law, and the stage matters more than usual. A section in reported text is evidence of what a committee wanted, not of what will govern a contract, and every word of section 1018 could be amended or struck on the floor or in conference. The planning value is in the direction rather than the date. This desk did not verify the current floor status of either chamber’s bill for this issue, and no date should be inferred from the above.

Assessment: two of the section’s own requirements are worth putting together. It instructs the Secretary to consider preventing over-concentration of workload, and it requires an assessment of workforce capacity and dry dock and pier availability before any award. Both sit inside a structure that assigns a whole vessel category to one holder for at least five years. So a yard’s own capacity figures would become an input to who gets a category, which is a different exercise from bidding a single availability on price and schedule.

Bottom line: the direction of travel is multi-year assignment of whole ship categories to single yards, it exists so far only as committee-reported text, and the document that would matter first is the pre-award capacity report rather than the award itself.

Sources: *H.R. 8800, section 1018, as reported in the House* {.sources}

The Waterfront Brief is compiled weekly by the B2 vault's research engine from NAVSEA and Navy releases, DVIDS, USNI News, Stars and Stripes, Government Executive, Maine Public, GAO and congressional records, USASpending award records, defense.gov, and trade press, then synthesized and labeled by hand (125 sources staged this week, 4 quarantined). Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and INDOPACOM partners. Freshness policy: every article's anchor source is under 12 months old; this issue's anchors run from six weeks to four months old, and older material appears only as clearly dated context. Contract-record figures are read directly from the USASpending API rather than from press summaries. FACT means the named source says it, not that this desk has independently verified it; Assessment is analysis built only on facts stated above it. Corrections welcome; the staged sources are retained for audit.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Nearest first, filling the page (dates and registration deadlines exactly as organizers publish them). **Bold** marks a decision that closes inside the next 60 days.

Dates	Event	Register by	Why it matters
Aug 18-19, 2026	National Shipbuilding Research Program (NSRP) Electrical Technologies Panel Meeting, SEL, Pullman, WA (also virtual)	None published (Cvent link open)	The panel behind the fiber-optic switchboard-sensing pilot; tech-transfer venue for electrical condition monitoring
Aug 24-25, 2026	NSRP (National Shipbuilding Research Program) Workforce & Compliance Panel Meeting, IHMC, Pensacola, FL	In-person closed Aug 13, 2026	Cross-yard workforce practices while the Navy chases its 250,000-hire target
Aug 25-27, 2026	PSNS & IMF Sustainment Accelerator, Kitsap Conference Center, Bremerton, WA (National Center for Manufacturing Sciences, with Puget Sound Naval Shipyard and Intermediate Maintenance Facility)	Not published	A public yard publishing the gaps it will be sold on: non-destructive testing, welding solutions, portable power and machining tools, 3D scanning and metrology, confined-space monitoring, fibre-optic splicing, unmanned systems
Sep 22-24, 2026	Fleet Maintenance & Modernization Symposium (FMMS) 2026, Virginia Beach, VA (American Society of Naval Engineers, ASNE)	Early bird thru Aug 16, 2026	The flagship fleet-maintenance event for exactly this work
Sep 29 - Oct 2, 2026	Shipbuilders Council of America (SCA) Fall Membership Meeting 2026, Washington, DC	Members only; none published	The surface-repair industrial base's Hill-and-Navy engagement window
Oct 28-29, 2026	Arctic Operations Symposium 2026, MITAGS, Baltimore, MD (ASNE)	Not published yet	Cold-region sustainment, hull and machinery readiness
Nov 16-17, 2026	Navy Procurement Outlook Summit, Reston, VA (Defense Leadership Forum)	Eventbrite open; no deadline published	Shipbuilding-plan and contracting priorities, with contracting-officer access
Dec 7-9, 2026	Technology, Systems & Ships / Combat Systems Symposium (TSS/CSS), George Mason University, Arlington, VA (ASNE)	Not published yet	Technology, systems and ships exchange near the NAVSEA customer
Jan 26-28, 2027	Military Additive Manufacturing Summit (MILAM), Tampa, FL	Tiers: Oct 2 / Dec 4; closes Jan 22	Metal and polymer print qualification and NAVSEA-spec adoption
Mar 23-25, 2027	NSRP All Panel Meeting 2027	"Coming soon" per NSRP	Where yard R&D ideas get socialized and teamed program-wide

Beyond the printed window, rolling in as it approaches: Indo Pacific 2027 International Maritime Exposition (Nov 2-4, 2027).